conservatives, as known from his widely publicised remarks on homosexuals – remarks seen by conservatives as an alarming attempt to change the teaching of the Church and as not going far enough by liberal Catholics. By the same token, the pope is not overly enthusiastic about pro-life campaigners (in the US), as long as some of them either defend or are untroubled by capital punishment and the unfettered freedom to bear arms.

This was clearly evident from the Vatican's official reaction to the June 2022 ruling of the U.S. Supreme Court on Roe v. Wade. Italian Archbishop Vincenzo Paglia, president of the Pontifical Academy for Life, said that 'the killing of an innocent human being can never be considered a "right". This goes for abortion, it goes for war, it goes for the death penalty and for the selling and use of arms'.[211] Similarly, the pope is not too impressed by the Polish Church or by Mr Orbán in his defence of Christian Europe. Obviously, social conservatism in Central Europe or in the United States is not something close to his heart: 'For example, a fantasy of national-populism in countries with Christian majorities is its defence of "Christian civilisation" from perceived enemies, whether Islam, Jews, the European Union, or the United Nations. […]. irreligious or superficially religious people vote for populists to protect their religious identity, unconcerned that fear and hatred of the other cannot be reconciled with the Gospel.'[212] But neither is he impressed by an increasingly individual society, in which personal freedom is turned 'into an ideology, creating a prism through which they judge everything'.[213] He is in fact concerned about 'the hyperinflation of the individual combined with weak institutions and the despotic control of the economy by a very few' and among those institutions 'the family has taken the hardest knock of all'.[214] In other words, he is no fan of the post-modern 'woke' agenda – he often speaks about all such ideologies as new forms of mental colonisation.

Concerns about European identity and guardianship of European values are not heard only in the Vatican. Philosopher and cultural theorist Kwame Anthony Appiah warns that 'values aren't a birthright: you need to keep caring about them. Living in the West, however you define it – being Western, however you define that – provides no guarantee that you will care about Western Civ'.[215] And he adds that 'what makes "us" a people, ultimately, is a commitment to governing a common life together',[216] and in another place: 'a nation is a group of people who think of themselves as